extraordinary wealth that had accumulated in the vaults of the Padmanabhaswamy Vishnu temple at Trivandrum.

As Independence approached in 1947 Travancore's Chief Minister, C. P. Ramaswamy Iyer, refused to accede to the Indian Union as most of the other Princely States were doing, believing that Travancore could go it alone on what he called the 'American model'. He encouraged the now elderly ruler, Maharaja Balarama Varma, to declare independence, leading to a violent uprising in the Alleppey region that was equally violently suppressed with the loss of several hundred lives. Iyer had to resign, and the maharaja then agreed that Travancore should join the Union. So in 1949 the two former kingdoms of Travancore and Cochin became a single state within the Indian Union, with the former Maharaja of Travancore taking on the largely symbolic role of governor. In 1956 this short-lived state became Kerala State, in the process gaining the district of Malabar but losing its four southernmost divisions to what became Tamil Nadu. In 1957 Kerala state's first communist government was elected to power and began a sweeping programme of reform under Chief Minister E. M. S. Namboodiripad, whose very name is an indicator of what huge shifts in attitude had taken place.

Throughout this period the royal family of Travancore retained managing control of the Padmanabhaswamy temple in the form of a temple trust. This continued right up to 2009, when an elderly Brahmin named T. P. Sundarajan filed a writ challenging the royal family's authority over the temple. Sundarajan was a committed if eccentric devotee who, according to the temple priests, had frequently disturbed the sleeping Lord Vishnu by chanting loud 'wake-up' *shloka*s. Whatever his motives, Sundarajan's writ eventually led, in July 2011, to the Supreme Court appointing him a member of a panel charged with drawing up a complete inventory of the temple treasury, believed to be contained in six underground vaults. The contents of four